



The brothers Karamazov go abroad: A dataset of Russian leaders' foreign visits

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Abstract

This study presents the “Russia Visits Dataset,” which records high-level visits by Russian leaders to foreign countries from 1991 to 2023, including official trips by presidents, prime ministers, and foreign ministers. Using probit regression analysis, the study reveals that strategic interests—such as political, economic, and military factors—predominantly shape the distribution of Russian leader visits, while domestic influences are found to have a limited role. The analysis also emphasizes the importance of international organizations, particularly the Eurasian Economic Union (EEU), as a key driver of Russian state visits. The results suggest that previous visits by different leaders influence subsequent visits, indicating a coordinated and sequential approach to Russian diplomacy. The “Russia Visits Dataset” serves as a valuable resource for understanding the dynamics of Russian foreign policy and provides a foundation for future research into the motivations, impacts, and diplomatic strategies of Russian leader visits.

Keywords Russia · Leader visits · International organizations

JEL Classification P52 · F50 · F53

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1 Introduction

This study delves into the complex landscape of Russian leader visits to foreign countries, examining their distribution patterns and the underlying factors that shape these diplomatic engagements. Leader visits transcend mere ceremonial gestures, serving as potent tools that influence a wide array of international relations dynamics. This multifaceted influence extends from economic diplomacy to public perception, impacting leader survival, interstate conflicts, and even the distribution of visits themselves.

To illuminate these intricate relationships, this paper introduces a novel dataset, the “Russia Visits Dataset,” which provides a comprehensive record of high-level Russian leader visits to foreign countries between 1991 and 2023. The dataset includes official, multilateral, goodwill, public, and private visits by Russian presidents, prime ministers, and foreign ministers. It is the first of its kind to document Russian high-level visits, offering a valuable resource for analyzing the country’s foreign policy objectives and diplomatic strategies. This study, utilizing this unique dataset, focuses on official visits, a crucial category that represents high-level diplomatic engagements, and employs a probit model to identify the key determinants driving the distribution patterns of these visits.

The contribution of this study is threefold. Firstly, the research on high-level leader visits predominantly focuses on leader visits by the two superpowers, China and the U.S., with few exceptions. For the countries other than the U.S., the main challenge is the scarcity of data, as the majority of countries do not provide systemic and reliable information on leader visits. This hinders the ability to test theories on both the factors influencing these visits and their outcomes. To our knowledge, this study utilizes the first comprehensive dataset covering Russian high-level visits. By presenting this dataset, we address a gap in the leader visit literature bringing Russia to the fold.

Secondly, this study represents the first analytical and structured effort to understand the factors influencing Russian high-level visits. In order to comprehend the sophisticated, dynamic and interlinked dynamics and established routines of diplomatic relationships, our analysis examination of how previous visits by the president, prime minister, and foreign minister may influence their upcoming visits. We employ military, political, economic variables, among others, to decipher determinants of Russian leader visits.

Thirdly, this study investigates the international organization dimension of Russian foreign policy by examining the role of membership in the Eurasian Economic Union (EEU), the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO), and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in Russian leader visits. The analysis proposes a quantifiable method to understand the evolution and implementation of regional priorities within Russian foreign policy, providing insights into how these priorities are factored into foreign policy decision-making. Ultimately, this study contributes to the broader understanding of leader visits as tools of international relations, particularly in the context of Russia’s geopolitical strategies and global engagement.

This data analysis article is structured into five main sections. The second section presents a thorough review of the existing literature on leader visits, highlighting their multifaceted impact on international relations and Russian context. The third

section delves into the creation and characteristics of the “Russia Visits Dataset.” This section also explores the persistence of visits, their average duration, and the specific roles of international organizations such as the SCO, ASEAN, and EEU in influencing visit patterns. The fourth section employs probit regression models to analyze the political, economic and international organization determinants of leader visits, focusing on the distinct roles of the president, prime minister, and foreign minister. The concluding section summarizes our findings, highlighting the key determinants of Russian leader visits. This section ends with an exploration of the study’s limitations and potential avenues for future research.

2 Leader visits in perspective

2.1 Background literature

Foreign leader visits, despite their significant costs and time commitment, are a cornerstone of international relations (Goldstein, 2008, 164–167). The selection of countries for these visits is a complex decision, influenced by both domestic and international considerations. Domestically, the necessity of a visit can be politically sensitive, especially in democracies, where opposition parties may criticize it as favoritism, a waste of time, and a misuse of resources. Internationally, visit preferences can strain relations with countries overlooked. This necessitates a framework explaining the factors driving these high-stakes choices: leaders allocate scarce resources (time, money, political capital) to destinations crucial for their nation’s material interests (economic gains), national identity (symbolic importance), and international status (prestige).

Existing research approaches leader visit decisions from two perspectives: consequences and motivations (Balci & Pulat, 2024). The first analyzes the impacts of visits on various international outcomes, such as bilateral trade (Lavallée & Lochard, 2022; Beaulieu et al., 2020; Nitsch, 2007), the visiting country’s image (Goldsmith et al., 2021), the leader’s survival prospects in the visited country (Wang et al., 2023; McManus, 2018; Bader, 2015; Malis & Smith, 2021) and military spending (Kim, 2024). These findings indirectly suggest strategic visit planning to enhance national interests. Alternatively, analyses of these visits reveal differing prioritization strategies. U.S. leaders tend to focus on countries with significant military capabilities, major economic ties, or political alignment, and those considered great powers (Lebovic, 2018; McManus & Yarhi-Milo, 2017; Lebovic & Saunders, 2016). In contrast, Chinese visits appear driven by factors such as population size, GDP, and great power status (Wang & Stone, 2023). Studies consistently show the influence of a country’s status on high-level visits (Mesquita & Chien, 2021; Kastner & Saunders, 2012).

The inherent costs of diplomatic visits—the leader’s time, financial resources, and opportunity costs—enhance their credibility. Leaders could use these resources to address domestic issues, especially during election cycles (Lebovic & Saunders, 2016). The very act of undertaking a visit, despite these costs, signals commitment. The public nature of visits, amplified by media coverage, increases audience costs,

making it difficult for leaders to deviate from commitments (McManus & Yarhi-Milo, 2017; McManus, 2018). These reputational costs are unique to the visiting leader, reinforcing the gravity of the commitment, contingent on their remaining tenure.

However, the literature, largely focused on great powers, may not fully apply to small and medium sized states (Balci, 2024b). Factors like a leader's survival prospects, relevant for powerful nations, might not be a primary concern for states other than great powers. We need a more sophisticated approach that considers how context-specific factors affect visit decisions in different countries. The symbolic weight of a visit, particularly from a powerful nation's leader, is considerable (Wang et al., 2023; Malis & Smith, 2021). A high-profile visit acts as a powerful endorsement, signaling the host country's importance and potentially deterring adversaries (Lee & Kim, 2024). This may not be the case for countries other than great powers (Balci, 2024b).

A comprehensive framework must consider the interplay of domestic, strategic, political and economic factors determining diplomatic travels. Political interests, particularly security relationships, strongly influence visit patterns (Debs & Goemans, 2010; Wood & Peake, 1998; Thomson, 2020). Leaders prioritize visits to allies, especially during crises, while visits to adversaries are less frequent. Domestic political factors also play a crucial role. Leaders with low political capital might use foreign policy to influence domestic politics (Cavari & Ables, 2019; Kim, 2024; Ostrander & Rider, 2019; Potter, 2013). This data article will utilize a combination of factors mainly discussed in the literature to understand determinants of Russian foreign policy visits.

2.2 Russian context

The preceding part examined leader visit decisions to a large extent through a lens shaped by the experiences of major global powers, emphasizing factors such as domestic political pressures and the strategic pursuit of national interests within a relatively stable international order. However, the subsequent discussion shifts to the distinctly different context of contemporary Russia, a nation operating under a highly centralized authoritarian system facing considerable geopolitical challenges and actively seeking to reshape its regional sphere of influence (Karaganov, 2016). This necessitates a reconsideration of the driving factors behind Russian foreign leader visits, moving away from a framework primarily focused on democratic accountability and towards one that emphasizes the consolidation of power, the pursuit of regional hegemony, and the unique constraints and opportunities presented by Russia's adversarial relationship with the West.

Since the 2008 Russia-Georgia war, Russia has positioned itself as a Eurasian superpower, vehemently opposing the Western-led liberal international order. Events such as the Russo-Georgian War, the so-called "color revolutions," NATO expansion, and the Russian invasion of Ukrainian territories have fueled Moscow's gradual shift away from the West and its pursuit of regional hegemony (Strycharz, 2022; Clunan, 2018). Against this backdrop, visits by the Russian president send a powerful signal, both to the host country and the international community. Hosting the Russian president, much like a visit from the U.S. president, signifies an endorsement of the host

as a valuable partner. However, the consequences differ significantly, often involving considerable risks for the receiving nation (Chou, 2017). In this vein, Vladimir Putin's September 2, 2024, was significant for Mongolia due to hosting state's energy dependency and assurance agreements signed with Russia. However, the visit raised more attention for its symbolic significance. This was Putin's first trip to an ICC member state since the Court issued an arrest warrant for him in March 2023.¹ The visit raised questions about Mongolia's adherence to the Rome Statute and potentially its continued membership in the ICC. Mongolia may face with the consequence of withdrawing from the Rome Statute and/or removing its judge from the ICC.²

Analysis of leader visits reveals that priorities often include reassuring and supporting allies during crises. For instance, the U.S., with its 51 defense agreements worldwide, prioritizes visits to these partner nations to maintain its global military alliances (Lee & Kim, 2024, p. 2). Russia, possessing defense pacts with 28 countries, primarily in Asia and Africa, pursues a similar, though more geographically focused, strategy to consolidate its Eurasian hegemony and cultivate relationships with like-minded nations beyond its immediate region (Cameron & Orenstein, 2012; Tolstrup, 2009). This approach was evident in President Vladimir Putin's defense agreements signed with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un in Pyongyang (June 19, 2024) and Kyrgyz President Sooronbai Jeenbekov in Bishkek (March 28, 2019). Both leaders emphasized the significance of these agreements in elevating their countries' relationships with Russia to alliance level.³

In contrast to the U.S. leaders, Russian leaders do not need to cope with domestic constraints. They do not face changing political circumstances, and are not subject to establishment oversight, domestic policy pressures, or the limitations of a lame-duck session. Vladimir Putin's long tenure as president precludes significant shifts in administration and a strong state apparatus limits the influence of political and institutional factors on foreign policy decision-making (Rak & Bäcker, 2020). Large-scale protests erupted in Russia in January 2021, triggered by Alexei Navalny's arrest upon returning from Germany and fueled by his exposé of a lavish palace allegedly linked to President Putin. These demonstrations represented some of the biggest anti-government protests in Russia in over a decade.⁴ Widespread protests against Russia's invasion of Ukraine erupted globally, including within Russia itself, resulting in thousands of arrests of protestors. Despite government repression, numerous Russians from all walks of life publicly condemned the war and called for an end to hostilities, signing open letters and engaging in various forms of dissent, from petitions to individual acts of resistance. This widespread opposition underscored the

¹ See, <https://www.icc-cpi.int/situations/ukraine>.

² Dragan Stavljanić, "Putin's Mongolia Visit Shows Limits of International Criminal Court," *RFE/RL*, September 5, 2024, at <https://www.rferl.org/a/putin-mongolia-visit-icc-arrest-explainer-russia/33106069.html>.

³ "Kyrgyzstan: Putin visit brings lavish deals and vows of a bright future," *Eurasianet*, March 29, 2019, at <https://eurasianet.org/kyrgyzstan-putin-visit-brings-lavish-deals-and-vows-of-a-bright-future>; "Putin flies into North Korea with promise to back it against the US," *Reuters*, June 19, 2024, at <https://www.reuters.com/world/putin-vows-take-north-korea-ties-higher-level-2024-06-17/>.

⁴ "Navalny protests: Thousands across Russia join demonstrations," *BBC*, February 1, 2021, at <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-europe-55876033>;

depth of anti-war sentiment within Russia.⁵ None of these protests, nor any others, led to legislative or political changes, or shifted leaders' attention to foreign policy. This indicates a lack of domestic political constraints on the domestic-foreign policy relationship.

From practice perspective, Russian foreign policy showcases habits and routines rendering diplomatic patterns like China and the U.S. Russia's difference is concentrated efforts of consolidating hegemonic role in Eurasia through political, economic and military relations versus the U.S. global orientation and China's trade and reputation positioning in a wider geography. Russia also has a diplomatic pattern to establish regional organizations, i.e. EEU and CSTO, and leverage over member countries to keep them in its sphere of influence (Sakwa, 2021). To exemplify, Russia has announced that the Eurasian Economic Union (EEU), established on May 29, 2014, during President Putin's visit to Astana, will foster a unified market and coordinated economic policies among its former Soviet member states in the following years. President Putin lauded the EEU's creation as a historically significant step, elevating member states to a new level of integration. Meanwhile, then-President Nursultan Nazarbayev envisioned it as a bridge between East and West.⁶

While existing research illuminates the factors driving leader visits for major global powers, focusing on strategic interests and domestic political pressures, a nuanced understanding requires considering the unique context of states like Russia. Russia's authoritarian political system, geopolitical challenges, and pursuit of regional hegemony necessitate a framework that prioritizes power consolidation and the pursuit of Eurasian influence over democratic accountability. The analysis of Russian diplomacy reveals a pattern of reinforcing alliances, particularly in defense agreements, within its sphere of influence and leveraging regional organizations to maintain control. Unlike the U.S. or China, Russia's diplomatic approach is characterized by concentrated efforts to build its Eurasian hegemony across political, economic, and military domains, and reaching out to like-minded states beyond immediate geography rather than broad global engagement, highlighting the need for context-specific models when analyzing leader visit decisions.

3 A new dataset of high-level Russian diplomatic visits

Our study relies on the comprehensive and new dataset of Russian leader's visits to foreign countries, "Russia Visits Dataset". The dataset consists of official visits, multilateral visits, goodwill visits, public visits and private visits by the Russian leaders. Such high-level visits send significant signals to the world indicating Russian support for the host countries they visit, as well as support for the incumbent leader (McManus & Yarhi-Milo, 2017; McManus, 2018; Malis & Smith, 2021). Our focus

⁵ Katerina Tertychnaya "Russian Protests Following the Invasion of Ukraine," *PONARS Eurasia Policy Memo*, No. 841, April 2023.

⁶ "Kazakhstan, Belarus and Russia Sign Historic Treaty Creating Eurasian Economic Union," *Astana Times*, May 29, 2014, at <https://astanatimes.com/2014/05/kazakhstan-belarus-russia-sign-historic-treaty-creating-eurasian-economic-union/>.

lies on the visits made by presidents, prime ministers, and foreign ministers, as they represent high-level diplomatic engagements. Initially, considering foreign ministers as high-ranking leaders might seem counterintuitive. While foreign ministers hold esteemed positions, they often operate in the shadow of presidents or prime ministers. However, despite their relatively lower profile, their visits also garner significant media attention and effectively convey messages to both allies and adversaries.

3.1 Data collection

The dataset covers the visits made by presidents, prime ministers, and foreign ministers over the years between 1991 and 2023. It includes, among others, visits by President Boris Yeltsin made between 1991 and 1999, visits by President Vladimir Putin between 2000 and 2008, visits made by President Dmitry Medvedev from 2008 to 2012 and visits by President Vladimir Putin made between 2012 and 2023.⁷ The dataset encompasses visits to all United Nations member countries, as well as visits to Palestine and the Vatican, both of which are non-UN members, with the exception of Russia itself.

The dataset is compiled from six separate sources that mutually complement and support each other: (i) Presidential foreign visits between 2000 and 2023 sourced from the President of the Russian Federation's official website (ii) Prime Minister foreign visits between 2008 and 2023 from the Government of the Russian Federation's official website, (iii) Foreign Minister foreign visits between 2000 and 2023 from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation's official website, (iv) the LexisNexis database for wide-ranging collection of news (v) keyword-based Google search, and (vi) Wikipedia entries documenting high-level international visits. A word-based algorithm incorporating the names of presidents, prime ministers, and foreign ministers, along with the keyword "visit," was developed. Irrelevant news articles were filtered by authors from Google and LexisNexis search results to generate leader-focused summaries of visits. Finally, all official Russian government websites were consulted to verify the dates and destinations of foreign visits from 1991 to 2023.

"Russia Visits Dataset" incorporates rich supplementary information about the nature of the visits. We have a supporting document for validation of each leader visit. This includes details such as the country of the visit, the timing (start and end dates) of the visit, the duration of the visit, whether the visit is conducted as a group of countries in one trip, the purpose (official, multilateral, private), and the description of the content of the visit. Note that, multiple visits by high-ranking officials (such as visits to the same country by different leaders or visits by the same leader to different countries) may refer to the same supporting document. This is especially true when Russian officials travel to several countries at once. If a number of countries are visited in a single trip, we also provide the sequence in which they were visited. In fact, for a powerful country as Russia, even the sequence in which the

⁷ The list of prime ministers and foreign ministers between 1991 and 2023 are provided in the Appendix, Table A1.

visits occur can be important since the order in which countries are visited can signal diplomatic priorities and strategic relationships.⁸

A related dataset is that of Goldsmith et al. (2021), which compiles data on 86 high-level visits from nine countries, including 21 Russian visits, to analyze the impact of these visits on public opinion through poll data. While their focus is on the causal effect of visits on the approval or disapproval of the visiting leader, our dataset significantly expands on this by covering 2,063 Russian high-level visits. This broader dataset provides a more comprehensive and detailed record of Russian diplomatic activities, enabling wider analyses beyond public opinion and contributing to the literature in both scope and depth.

3.2 The characteristics of Russian high-level visits

The “Russia Visits Dataset” comprises details of 2063 visits between 1991 and 2023, including instances where countries received visits from the president, prime minister, and foreign minister within the same year. Notably, our analysis focuses exclusively on official visits and this approach is consistent with studies by Li (2015), Lebovic and Saunders (2016), Koliev and Lundgren (2021) and Wang and Stone (2023). These studies similarly exclude multilateral visits (such as participation in international forums like the UN) and private visits that lack explicit diplomatic purposes, to ensure the analysis is centered on direct, state-level diplomatic engagements.

Official visits are most representative of the direct bilateral relationships between Russia and the host countries, reflecting explicit support or intent without the complexity of multilateral or private motivations. The official visits, which accounts for the almost 69% of all visits consists of 448 presidential, 194 prime minister and 781 foreign minister visits.

3.2.1 Historical/Temporal distribution

In Fig. 1, we present the pattern of visits by Russian high leaders over the years. Overall, this pattern shows visible fluctuations suggesting a cyclical nature of diplomatic engagements, with periods of increased and decreased activity. Still, from 2000 to 2014 there exists relative stability in the number of visits, where the number generally remains above 40 visits per year. There is a peak in 2010 with 74 visits. The peak in diplomatic visits by Russian high leaders observed in 2010, may be attributed to Russia’s pursuit of consolidation of sphere of influence in the nearby geographies between 2009 and 2013 in post-Georgia conflict period. Furthermore, as part of this strategy, Russia took steps to promote economic integration within the EEU. Remarkably, Russia signed a customs union agreement with Belarus and Kazakhstan, in 2010 and 2012 respectively. Additionally, year 2010 corresponds to one year before the free trade area treaty, which Russia signed with 11 Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) countries, excluding Georgia.

⁸ The sequence may reflect which countries are considered more important in the context of specific diplomatic missions, regional influence, or global strategy. Therefore, documenting the sequence can offer valuable insights into the diplomatic intent behind these trips.

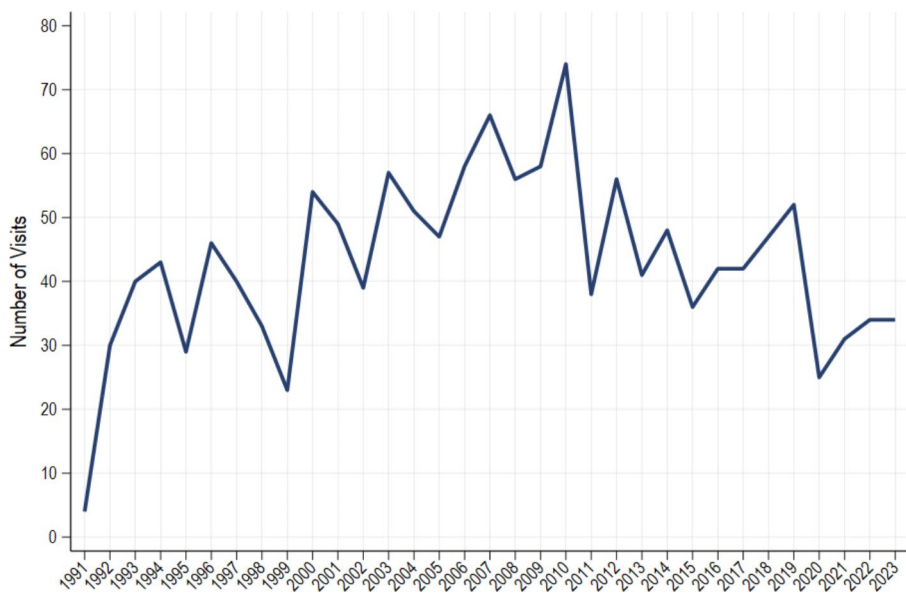


Fig. 1 Total visits by Russian high-level leaders (1991–2023). Source: Russian visits dataset

After 2014, the effects of this new orientation became evident in particular in the aftermath of the Ukraine Crisis and the subsequent severance of relations with the West. This decline is evident in the decrease in visits in 2015 to the Western countries. As part of this strategy, Russia has pivoted towards the east, focusing on becoming more integrated into the neighboring regions and enhancing political and economic ties with Asia-Pacific countries. The impact of this strategy can be observed in the visit numbers from 2016 to 2019. However, it is noteworthy that the number of official diplomatic visits decline significantly after 2019, which is partly attributable to the COVID-19 pandemic and the escalating conflict and war between Russia and Ukraine.

In Fig. 2, we compare the total number of official visits by foreign ministers, presidents, and prime ministers over the years. Overall, foreign minister visits consistently outnumber visits of president and prime minister, except for a few instances where president visits surpass foreign minister visits. Additionally, prime minister visits generally remain the lowest among the three categories. The peak in 2010 is evident across all categories of visits, which is particularly prominent in foreign minister visits, with 31 visits recorded, and followed by 30 visits by president and 13 visits by prime ministers. We observe that the correlation between president and foreign minister visits shows a moderate positive relationship, with a Pearson correlation coefficient of 0.66, after 2010. However, the trends are not perfectly synchronized. This may indicate a coordinated approach and a cohesive diplomatic agenda in Russian diplomatic engagements after 2010.

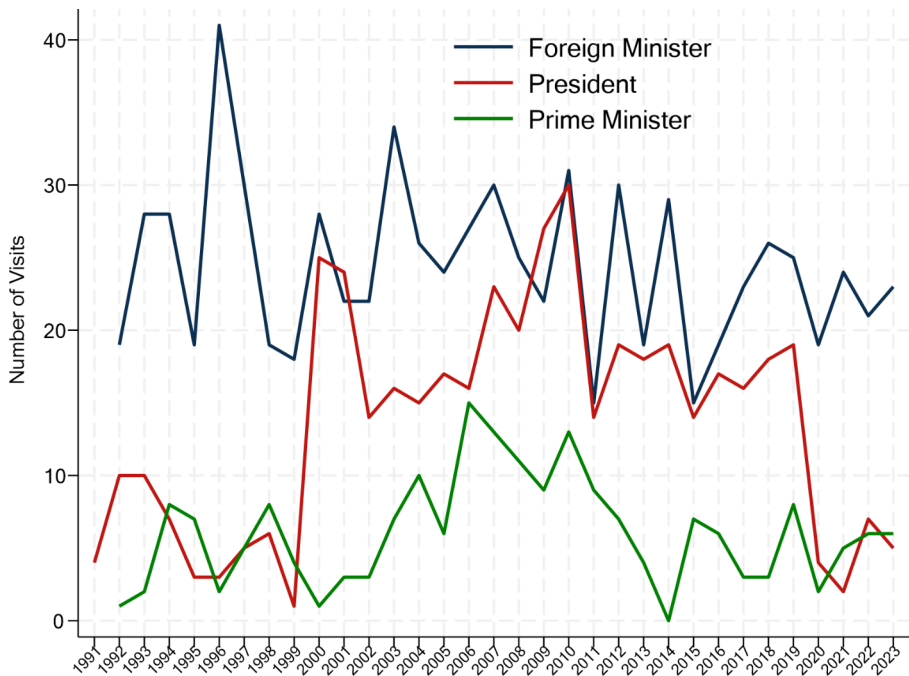


Fig. 2 Total visits by Russian leaders (1991–2023). Source: Russian visits dataset

3.2.2 Geographical distribution

Russian presidents have embarked on diplomatic visits to 80 different countries from 1991 to 2023.⁹ Presidential visits are geographically concentrated, with Europe and Central Asia receiving the highest number of visits (Figs. 3 and 4). Of all countries in this region, Kazakhstan has been visited most frequently, with a total of 34 presidential visits (Fig. 3). The figures reveal that presidential visits are more frequent in neighboring countries or regions, which may signal a negative effect of distance. Additionally, we highlight the top five countries most frequently visited by Russian Presidents during this period in Fig. 5.¹⁰ Kazakhstan is followed by China (26 visits) and Germany (25 visits) as the most frequently visited countries during this period. The frequent visits to Kazakhstan, Ukraine and Belarus are unsurprising given the historical ties, geographical proximity, energy security and possible other trade benefits (Custer et al., 2018).

These visits also signify the role of the EEU and the SCO. On the other hand, Russia's relationship with China has strengthened significantly in recent years, with both countries following closer economic, political, and military ties. Both countries are members SCO and ASEAN in different capacities. Presidential visits to Germany

⁹ Abkhazia, the Vatican, and South Ossetia are counted among the countries visited.

¹⁰ The list of the top 16 countries most visited by Russian high-level leaders between 1991 and 2023 can be found in Appendix Table A2.

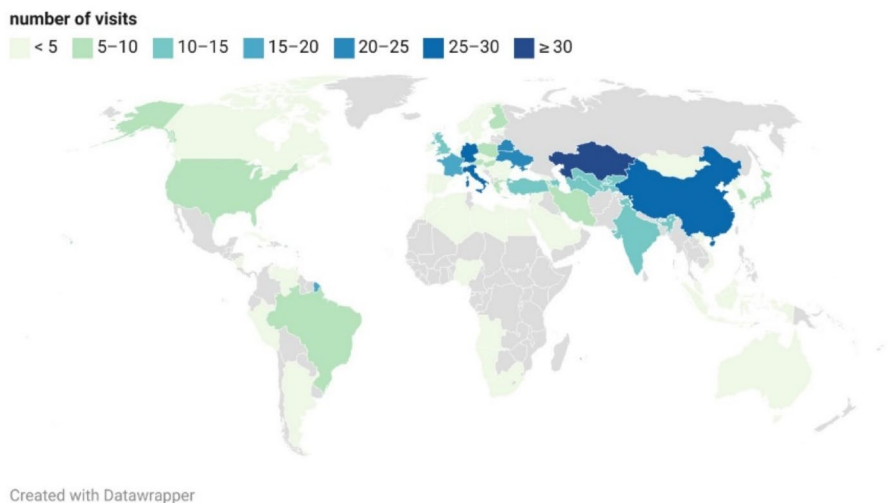


Fig. 3 Geographic distribution of Russian presidential visits (1991–2023). Source: Russian visits dataset

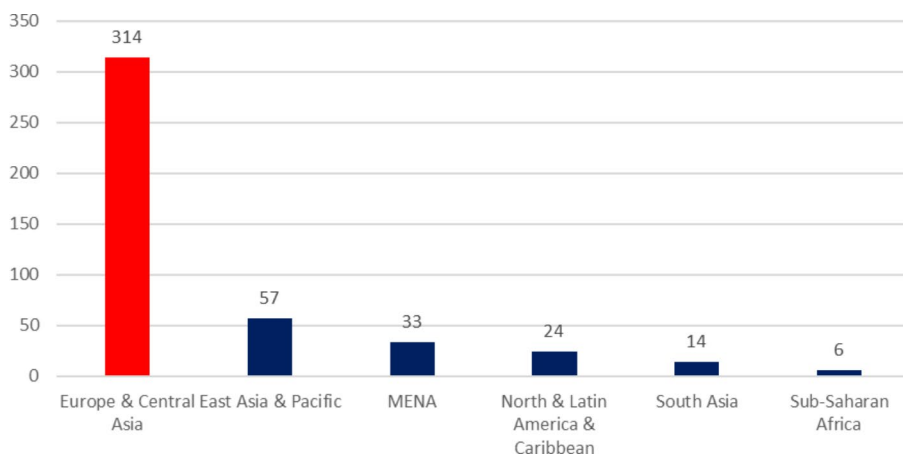


Fig. 4 Regional breakdown of Russian presidential visits (1991–2023). Source: Russian visits dataset

reflect Russia's keen interest in maintaining strong diplomatic relations with major powers and European Union (EU). Visits to EU countries as well as Turkey and India highlights the importance of trade and economic interests in Russian diplomacy (Table A2).

Given that the 2008 Russo-Georgian War is a pivotal reference in discussions on Russian foreign policy—marked by strained relations between Russia and Western nations, notably the U.S. and EU—we have segmented our dataset into two periods: before and after 2008 (Fig. 5). Among the top five countries most visited, Ukraine experienced the most significant decline in visits after 2008. The situation deteriorated

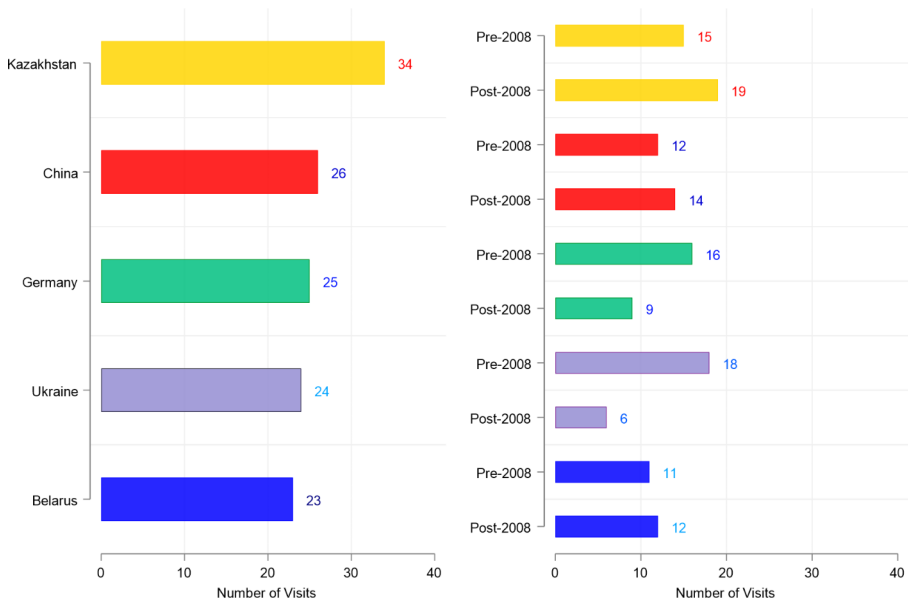


Fig. 5 Top five countries most frequently visited by Russian presidents (1991–2023). Source: Russian visits dataset

rated notably in 2014 with Russia's invasion of Crimea from Ukraine, a move that drastically affected diplomatic interactions.

Between 1991 and 2023, Russian foreign ministers conducted diplomatic visits to 120 different countries, while prime ministers visited only 63. Geographical distributions of these visits are depicted in Figures A1, A2 and Tables A3, A4 in the Appendix¹¹, revealing similar yet distinct patterns.¹² Notably, Russian high-level leaders frequently re-visit the same countries across different years.

Table 1 below presents various combinations of diplomatic interactions, categorizing visits by the presidents, prime ministers, and foreign ministers for 1991–2023. For instance, 54 countries received visits from all three leaders, while 57 countries, primarily in Africa, South Asia, the Caribbean, and Oceania, did not receive visits from any Russian leader during the specified period. Further, only 3 countries, including Estonia, Malaysia, and Nigeria, were visited solely by the President, without visits from the Prime Minister or Foreign Minister.

¹¹ The online appendix can be found on the *Review of International Organizations* website.

¹² The list of the top 14 countries most visited by Russian foreign ministers from 1992 to 2023 is provided in Appendix Table A3. Similarly, the list of the top 10 countries most visited by Russian prime ministers from 1991 to 2023 can be found in Appendix Table A4. The determination of the number of countries displayed—such as the top 10—was based on identifying natural cutoff points within the data.

Table 1 Diplomatic Interaction
Sub-matrix: President, Prime Minister, and Foreign Minister visits

	Yes-President	No-President
<i>Yes-Prime, Yes-Foreign</i>	54 (e.g. China, India, Belarus)	5 (e.g. Iceland, Kuwait, Oman)
<i>Yes Prime, No Foreign</i>	--	1 (Cambodia)
<i>No Prime, Yes Foreign</i>	14 (e.g. Indonesia, Jordan, Ireland)	38 (e.g. Sudan, Uganda, Tunisia)
<i>No-Prime, No-Foreign</i>	3 (e.g. Estonia, Malaysia, Nigeria)	57 (e.g. Burundi, Chad, Zambia)

“Yes” and “No” columns indicate whether a specific diplomatic interaction (i.e. official visit) occurred. The numbers in each cell represent the count of occurrences falling into each category

Table 2 Persistence in diplomatic visits

	President		Prime M.		Foreign M.	
	All	Pre=1	All	Pre=1	All	Pre=1
Num. of Observations	5636	290	5636	159	5636	651
Num. of Visits (this year)	295	70	164	22	672	179
Probability of a Visit	5%	24%	3%	14%	12%	27%

Visit($t-1$)=1 is denoted by Pre=1 indicating a visit in the previous year

3.2.3 Persistence

Table 2 presents an analysis of diplomatic visits based on interactions in the previous year. “Probability of Visit” row illustrates the likelihood of a visit occurring in each category. To illustrate, while the probability of any presidential visit in the current year is 5%, the regarding probability significantly increases to 24% if there was a presidential visit in the previous year. The table reveals that the likelihood of a presidential visit significantly increases following a visit in the previous year, while there is a similar picture for the foreign minister visits. Such considerable increase in the likelihood of leader visits following a visit in the previous year may indicate a persistence in diplomatic engagement strategies, possibly aimed at strengthening strategic alliances and reinforcing diplomatic ties.

3.2.4 Duration

Figure 6 illustrates the duration of official visits by Russian leaders over the years. The straight lines in the figure represent the fitted values, indicating the general trend in the duration of official visits over time. These lines provide an average trend across all years for each category (president, prime minister, and foreign minister), helping to visualize any changes or consistencies in visit durations. Accordingly, across all Russian leaders, we observe a consistent pattern of visit durations ranging from one to three days. This suggests a steady diplomatic strategy or standardized protocol for visit lengths, regardless of political or economic changes. Presidential visits generally follow this trend but show a wider range of durations, with notably longer visits to more distant countries such as China, Japan, Italy, and the U.S.

Notes: The labeled countries in the figure are based on the duration of visits exceeding three days for foreign and prime ministers, and four days for presidents. However,

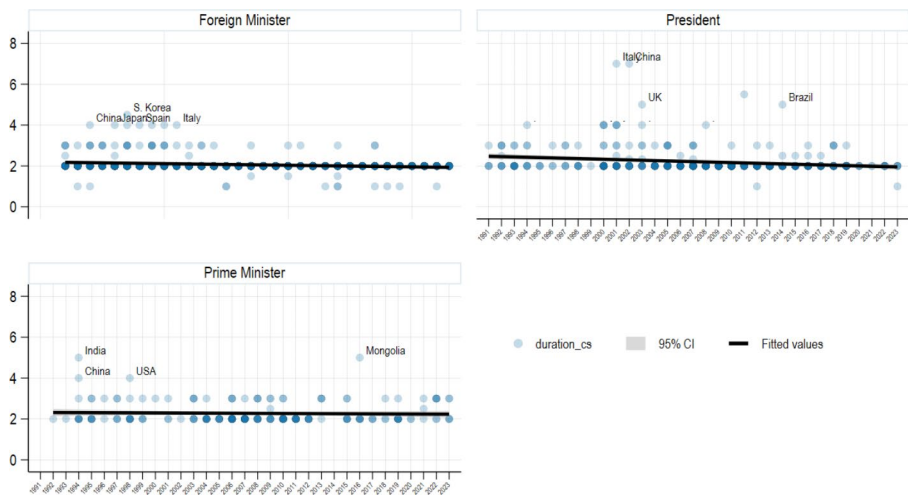


Fig. 6 Duration of the visits

if a country, such as Japan, received multiple visits longer than these thresholds, it is highlighted only once for clarity and to avoid overcrowding the figure with repetitive labels. Source: Russian Visits Dataset.

3.2.5 International organizations

We analyze the impact Russian engagement with three key international organizations—SCO, ASEAN, EEU—on Russian leader visits. First, Russia’s involvement in the SCO is characterized by consistent high-level engagement. Since its inception in 2001, Russian presidents have participated in all annual Heads of State Council meetings and typically conducted formal visits to the host country (Table 3). While Russian presidents participated through video conferencing in 2021 (Tajikistan) and 2023 (India) virtual meetings, the consistent state visits highlight Moscow’s commitment to the SCO’s goals of economic cooperation, security, and military affairs. Similarly, Russian prime ministers have also demonstrated their commitment by making official visits to all 18 host countries of Heads of Governments meetings during the period when Russia was not the chair country (Table 3). This dedication further reinforces the importance of the SCO in Russia’s foreign policy strategy. In this sense, SCO membership impacts on shaping the pattern of Russian presidential and prime minister visits.

Second, Russia’s relationship with ASEAN has evolved from a dialogue partner in 1996 to a strategic partner in 2018. This evolving partnership has seen Russian leaders actively engage with ASEAN, although the intensity of this engagement has fluctuated. While Russian presidents have visited Malaysia in 2005, Vietnam in 2010, and Singapore in 2018, marking key moments in the development of the Russia-ASEAN partnership (Table 4), there have been no visits since 2020. Additionally, there has been no participation in virtual meetings during this time. This pause in high-level engagement can be attributed to both critical attitudes within ASEAN

Table 3 SCO Chair State and Russian Leader visits

Year	Summits with Heads of States		Summits with Heads of Governments	
	President		Prime Minister	
2003	Russia	-	China	Yes
2004	Uzbekistan	Yes	Kyrgyzstan	Yes
2005	Kazakhstan	Yes	Russia	-
2006	China	Yes	Tajikistan	Yes
2007	Kyrgyzstan	Yes	Uzbekistan	Yes
2008	Tajikistan	Yes	Kazakhstan	Yes
2009	Russia	-	China	Yes
2010	Uzbekistan	Yes	Tajikistan	Yes
2011	Kazakhstan	Yes	Russia	-
2012	China	Yes	Kyrgyzstan	Yes
2013	Kyrgyzstan	Yes	Uzbekistan	Yes
2014	Tajikistan	Yes	Kazakhstan	Yes
2015	Russia	-	China	Yes
2016	Uzbekistan	Yes	Kyrgyzstan	Yes
2017	Kazakhstan	Yes	Russia	-
2018	China	Yes	Tajikistan	Yes
2019	Kyrgyzstan	Yes	Uzbekistan	Yes
2020	Russia (virtual)	-	India (Virtual)	No
2021	Tajikistan (virtual)	Yes	Kazakhstan (virtual)	Yes
2022	Uzbekistan	Yes	China (virtual)	Yes
2023	India (virtual)	Yes	Kyrgyzstan	Yes

Source: Russian visits dataset

Table 4 ASEAN chair state and Russian Leader visit

Year	Chair State	President	Prime M.
2005	Malaysia	Yes	No
2006	Philippines	No	No
2007	Singapore	No	No
2008	Thailand	No	No
2009	Thailand	No	No
2010	Vietnam	Yes	No
2011	Indonesia	No	No
2012	Cambodia	No	No
2013	Brunei	No	No
2014	Myanmar	No	Yes
2015	Malaysia	No	Yes
2016	Laos	No	Yes
2017	Philippines	No	Yes
2018	Singapore	Yes	No
2019	Thailand	No	Yes
2020	Vietnam (virtual)	No	No
2021	Brunei (virtual)	No	No
2022	Cambodia	No	No
2023	Indonesia	No	No

Source: Russian visits dataset

towards Russia's actions in Ukraine and pressure from Western powers. Despite this, Russia continues to utilize ASEAN summits to visit host countries, albeit through Foreign Minister visits (Table A5 in the Appendix), demonstrating a continued commitment to maintaining ties with the bloc.

Third, the EEU, an ambitious project for economic integration in the post-Soviet region, sees Russia as a dominant force. The consistent presence of Russian presidents and prime ministers at EEU summits and meetings (Table 5) underlines Russia's active role in shaping the organization's direction. Russian presidents have made formal visits to the chair country of the EEU since its inception in 2015, including virtual summits with Belarus in 2020 and Kazakhstan in 2021. Similarly, Russian prime ministers have also made formal visits to all chair countries except Kyrgyzstan in 2017. This consistent engagement demonstrates the centrality of the EEU in Russia's vision for regional economic integration and its desire to exert influence in the former Soviet space.

4 Econometric analysis: Determinants of leader visits

4.1 Argument and determinants

This section investigates the underlying factors driving the distribution patterns of Russian leader visits. We attest whether the distribution of Russian leader visits is driven by strategic interests (political, economic and military interests), domestic influences, multilateral interests and/or international experience.¹³ The goal of these visits is to promote Russian economic growth, strengthen bilateral partnerships, and participate in multilateral forums, among others. This analysis is informed by research on leader visits from other countries, such as the U.S. (Lebovic & Saunders, 2016) and China (Kastner & Saunders, 2012; Li, 2015; Wang, 2022).

The provided documentation demonstrates that visits often serve multiple purposes. For example, President Putin's 2016 visit to Kazakhstan combined attendance

Table 5 Eurasian economic union chair state and Russia leader visit

Year	Chair State	President	Prime M.
2015	Belarus	Yes	Yes
2016	Kazakhstan	Yes	Yes
2017	Kyrgyzstan	Yes	No
2018	Russia	-	-
2019	Armenia	Yes	Yes
2020	Belarus (virtual)	Yes	Yes
2021	Kazakhstan (virtual)	Yes	Yes
2022	Kyrgyzstan	Yes	Yes
2023	Russia	-	-

Source: Russian visits dataset

¹³ See, the framework of Lebovic and Saunders (2016) as well as Balci (2024a) and Kodila-Tedika and Khalifa (2024) for surveys of the determinants of leader visits.

at a business forum with the signing of agreements to enhance economic ties.¹⁴ His 2013 visit to Germany involved discussions with Chancellor Merkel on energy issues, regional and international developments, illustrating the strengthening of bilateral relations (Fig. 7).¹⁵ For official visits combined with selected IO meetings, please refer to Section 3.2.5.

4.1.1 Strategic interests

Economic variables When visiting other countries, Russian leaders have opportunity to engage in economic diplomacy to promote their nation's economic interests, particularly in bilateral trade and investment. To approximate the economic significance of a country to Russia, we will analyze several economic factors including population, GDP per capita, GDP growth, and natural resource wealth of the recipient countries. Larger countries and rich, fast-growing economies, with their significant market opportunities and influence on global politics, are expected to be more frequently visited by high-level leaders. Wang and Stone (2023) and Li (2015) show that countries with larger populations attract more visits from Chinese leaders. Furthermore, Custer et al. (2018) and Wang (2022) demonstrates that economic strength in terms

¹⁴ See, <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/trips/53022>.



Fig. 7 President Putin's official visit to Germany. Source: The document from the President of the Russian Federation's official website supports President Putin's official visits to Germany in June 2012. (<http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/15523>)

¹⁵ See, <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/trips/17845>.

of GDP (or GDP per capita) increases the frequency of Chinese leaders' visits. We hypothesize that Russian leaders are more likely to visit large, wealthy, and fast-growing economies. One could argue that leaders of resource-dependent countries are likely to visit resource-rich nations or have resource-driven objectives in their visits. Empirical evidence is limited to China where Kastner and Saunders (2012) and Wang and Stone (2023), find no significant relationship between Chinese leaders' visits and countries with abundant natural resources. Conversely, Custer et al. (2018) finds that resource-rich countries do, in fact, receive more elite-to-elite (official and military visits) diplomacy. Lee (2019) discover that top Chinese leaders are more inclined to visit countries with higher oil production. Regarding Russia, which is also a resource-rich country this pattern may differ. Russian leaders' visits may not strictly follow the same resource-driven logic due to differing geopolitical strategies and economic priorities.¹⁶ We test whether the presence of natural resources plays a significant role, indicating resource-driven objectives in Russian leader visits.

Another key economic variable representing strategic interests is trade, with foreign visits by national leaders often serving to address domestic needs (Kodila-Tedika & Khalifa, 2024). Leaders may travel abroad to access foreign markets for domestic products, fulfill local demand for consumer goods, or acquire essential materials, intermediate inputs, and machinery necessary for domestic production. Several studies highlight that trade relationships significantly influence these visits, focusing on aspects like total trade or exports (Lebovic & Saunders, 2016) and trade balance (Cavari & Ables, 2019). Malis and Smith (2021) found that U.S. presidential visits were positively influenced by exports from the U.S., but negatively by imports to the U.S. They conclude that their findings support Goldstein's (2008) concept of visits as a "trade sweetener," where such visits provide intangible benefits to the recipient country, but they aim to address domestic concerns. In fact, Goldstein argues that many leaders seek legitimacy by being recognized by more powerful governments, actively pursuing these invitations in exchange for favorable trade agreements.

In the Russian context, we argue that high-level visits can stimulate economic activity, particularly by increasing exports through expanded access to foreign markets. Additionally, an official visit from a powerful state like Russia can serve as a "trade sweetener," further boosting export opportunities. At the same time, we contend that visits may also be driven by heightened import activity. Therefore, we hypothesize that Russian high-level visits increase in response to both export and import activities.

Apart from the literature, instead of using exports, total trade, or trade balance we prefer to utilize exports and imports as separate controls in our estimations.¹⁷ This approach is particularly relevant in the Russian context, where the impact of imports is crucial. While Russia consistently runs a trade surplus due to strong natural resource exports, the trade balance is not a pressing concern. Instead, Russia's reli-

¹⁶ McFaul (2020) highlights that Russian interventions in Ukraine (2014) and Syria (2015) were driven by strategic interests and geopolitical imperatives rather than resource acquisition. This underscores that even in the context of military interventions, Russia's motivations extend beyond the pursuit of resources to encompass broader geopolitical strategies.

¹⁷ The results are robust to inclusion of total trade as a control variable.

ance on imports of consumer goods, technology, and industrial inputs is key for maintaining supply chain continuity and sustaining economic growth (Demetrio, 2019). By focusing on both exports and imports, we aim to capture the varied impact these trade activities have on shaping Russian high-level visits. We employ the exports to destination countries as a proportion of total Russian exports and the imports from recipient countries as a proportion of total Russian imports.

We also examine the distance between Moscow and the recipient capital to determine whether it poses a potential obstacle, due to the increased time and financial costs associated with travel to more distant states. Despite advances in travel technology, the impact of distance on leader visits remains significant. This suggests that strategic interests likely play a greater role in shaping diplomatic visit patterns. Countries that are geographically distant from Russia may be less strategically important than those in closer proximity, influencing the frequency and likelihood of high-level visits. Therefore, the further a country is from Russia, the less strategically salient it may be, and as a result, it could receive fewer visits from Russian leaders. Research indicates that both geographical and geodesic distances often discourage leaders from visiting distant countries (Balci, 2024a). For example, Kastner and Saunders (2012) finds that Chinese leaders are more inclined to visit neighboring countries with shared land borders, and Yan and Zhou (2023) expands this concept to include various dimensions of geographic differences, emphasizing the role of adjacency. Ostrander and Rider (2019) notes that the U.S. leaders tend to favor European and North American destinations due to easier access. While some studies, such as Wang and Stone (2023), identified a significant impact of distance on travel preferences, others, like Yan and Zhou (2023) and Li (2015) found no such effect.

Political variables Beyond economic motivations, Russian leaders' visits are also influenced by political factors. Research generally shows that strategically significant states attract more visits from other leaders (Balci, 2024a). Lebovic and Saunders (2016) and Goldsmith and Horiuchi (2009) find that the U.S. president and secretary of state tend to favor major powers, including UNSC permanent members, Japan, and Germany, in the post-Cold War era. This trend is also observed in Chinese leader visits, as confirmed by Wang and Stone (2023). Based on these findings, we include permanent UNSC membership, as well as Japan and Germany, as a variable for major powers in our analysis. We propose that Russia prioritizes visits to countries with significant global influence, either through their permanent UNSC membership or global power status, to strengthen diplomatic ties and potentially secure support for its foreign policy initiatives.

U.S. leaders often use diplomatic visits to reaffirm their commitment to states that share similar foreign policy stances. For instance, since the Cold War, U.S. officials have frequently made international trips to demonstrate support for allies, with reassuring them being a core aspect of U.S. foreign policy (Lebovic & Saunders, 2016; Blankenship, 2020). Following this reasoning, we hypothesize that Russian leaders may also be more inclined to visit states with political similarities. To capture “political proximities or tensions” and “the level of similarity of states in their comparative foreign policy stances”, the literature commonly focuses on “affinity of interest” and

utilizes data on voting similarity patterns in the UNGA. The UNGA is a unique forum where many states regularly vote on international issues, providing consistent data on political alignment (Voeten, 2000). This data has been widely used to measure political alignment (Kaya & Woo, 2022; Dreher et al., 2018; Wang, 2022; Wang & Stone, 2023). We hypothesize that Russian leaders are less likely to visit countries with high voting similarity to the U.S., reflecting potential geopolitical tensions or competing interests. We utilize the UNGA Voting Similarity variable, which is measured by the percentage of voting agreement with the U.S. in the UNGA. This variable indicates the recipient country's political alignment with the U.S.

We further hypothesize that Russian leaders are more likely to visit countries with high similarity to Russia in terms of alliance portfolios. To do so, we utilize Signorino and Ritter's (1999) S scores and Häge's (2011) scores, Scott's π and Cohen's κ , all calculated using the ATOP dataset (Chiba et al., 2015). These indices reflect political interest based on how closely alliance and foreign policy portfolios resemble one another.¹⁸ Higher values indicate stronger interest affinity. The variables record the degree to which Russia shares or opposes a country's interests. Out of these indexes, we select -Scott's π similarity score- to be included in our baseline estimations because it is a chance-corrected measure, which ensures that alliance similarities between countries are not due to random agreement. In the context of Russia's foreign policy, where alliances can vary in strength and purpose, Scott's π provides a more accurate reflection of true alignment by adjusting for chance. This makes it ideal for analyzing Russia's political and defense ties. Still, in the robustness section, we provide results using alternative similarity scores, such as Häge's (2011) Kappa scores (which have a 0.98 correlation with Scott's π) and weighted or unweighted S-scores.

Military variables Studies have shown that U.S. presidents and secretaries are more likely to visit countries with high military spending and significant imports of U.S. military equipment (Lebovic, 2018; Lebovic & Saunders, 2016). While this might suggest that Russia would similarly prioritize visits to countries with substantial military investments to foster defense partnerships and promote arms exports, this may not be the case. Strong military spending often correlates with close alliances, like NATO or the U.S., thus reducing susceptibility to Russian influence. Therefore, Russia might prioritize less militarized, less Western-aligned nations for new defense and geopolitical alliances, avoiding those with strong militaries and close ties to the West. These nations, with lower military spending, may offer opportunities for collaboration, particularly in regions where Russia seeks to expand its presence. Therefore, we hypothesize that Russian high-level visits are less frequent to countries with high military spending. To test our hypothesis, we employ the military spending ratio of destination countries as a proportion of total global military expenditure.

¹⁸ These scores are determined by ranking annual dyadic observations based on the strength of alliance treaty obligations. In this ranking, the highest weight is assigned to defense and/or offense obligations, followed by neutrality and/or consultation obligations, and finally, nonaggression obligations (Chiba et al., 2015).

Allied countries often engage in frequent visits due to shared security concerns. Lebovic and Saunders (2016) show that U.S. Presidents frequently visit their wartime allies. Similarly, the Russian government may be more inclined to visit its defense allies. In line with this, we hypothesize that Russian military allies receive more visits than other countries.

To proxy defense alliances, we first include the number of alliances with Russia based on data from the Alliance Treaty Obligations and Provisions (ATOP) project (Leeds et al., 2002) as a control variable, restricting the scope to formal defense pacts. A defense alliance is coded as 1 if a country shares a formal defense pact with Russia in a given year and 0 otherwise.

Next, we include Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO) membership as an additional control variable to represent defense allies. The CSTO, a military alliance led by Russia, consists of several former Soviet republics. As the largest member, Russia provides most of the alliance's military resources and serves as its *de facto* leader. The CSTO's primary goals are collective defense and regional stability. Current members include Russia, Armenia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan. Russia's role in the CSTO strengthens its influence over these states' security policies and maintains its strategic presence in the post-Soviet region, offering a formal mechanism for military intervention when needed. CSTO membership is coded as 1 for all member states from 1992 onwards, following the signing of the Collective Security Treaty.

4.1.2 Domestic influences

Domestic influences can be viewed from two perspectives: the internal dynamics of the visiting country and the domestic characteristics of the destination country. In many countries, bureaucratic, organizational, and political forces shape and constrain the actions of high-level officials, but we argue that this is less relevant in Russia. Unlike more pluralistic systems, where shifts from right- to left-leaning leadership or changes in leadership dynamics, such as the Congress-President distinction, can affect foreign visits, Russia's foreign policy since 2000 has been marked by continuity across administrations. Russia's consistent policies, irrespective of leadership changes, stem largely from its centralized, authoritarian political system under President Putin. Therefore, we focus on examining whether high-level visits are influenced by the domestic characteristics of potential destination countries rather than internal political changes within Russia.

Firstly, it can be argued that leaders of democratic regimes are more likely to visit countries with democratic governance than those with authoritarian regimes. This tendency reflects shared values and the promotion of democratic norms. While McManus and Yarhi-Milo (2017) find that regime type positively influences U.S. visits, Lebovic and Saunders (2016), Wang and Stone (2023) and Balci and Pulat (2024) find no significant relationship between regime type and the likelihood of visits from American, Chinese and Turkish leaders, respectively. Considering the autocratic political regime in Russia, we hypothesize that Russian leaders are less likely to visit countries with higher levels of democracy, as these nations may present challenges for Russia's regional ambitions and developing relations with autocratic

states. To account for this, we use electoral democracy index from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project.

Another important domestic characteristic of potential destination countries could be the presence of conflicts, which may significantly impact the likelihood of high-level visits. Conflicts can shape the priorities of foreign policy, either encouraging visits to support peace efforts or discouraging them due to instability or security risks. Therefore, the existence of conflicts in a destination country could be a key factor influencing the decision to undertake high-level visits. In the Russian context, we hypothesize that high-level visits are more likely to be influenced by the presence of conflicts in potential destination countries. We hypothesize that Russian leaders may prioritize visits to conflict zones where Russia has strategic interests, such as maintaining influence, supporting allies, or playing a role in conflict resolution.

4.1.3 International organization interests

While multilateral meetings do not directly lead to official visits, they make them more feasible by cutting down on costs associated with such visits. The frequency of official visits can also be influenced by the membership of the IOs hosting such meetings. Essentially, multilateral meetings create an environment that makes official visits more likely, although they are not the sole driving force behind them. This study incorporates three international organizations as variables: the SCO, ASEAN, and the EEU. SCO membership is denoted as 1 for all member states after 2003, ASEAN engagements as 1 starting 2005, and EEU membership as 1 from 2015 onward. These dates coincide with the implementation of mandatory leader visits within each organization (Potter, 2013). Given the frequency of leader visits associated with IOs, we hypothesize an increased likelihood of such visits for member states. Specifically, EEU and SCO members are expected to have positive impact on the visits from both the Russian president and prime minister. For ASEAN-linked summits, the effect of membership is predicted to primarily impact presidential visits.

4.1.4 International practice

Visit variables A practice-oriented framework of high-level visits views diplomacy as a social institution shaped by persistent norms, routine, repetition, and continuity. This perspective emphasizes not only the role of habitual behavior in selecting visits to strengthen diplomatic ties but also the patterns that may emerge between different diplomatic actors, such as the President and Foreign Minister. For example, there may be a coordinated dynamic where one official's visit influences whether or not the other follows. Lebovic and Saunders (2016) highlight that high-level visits by U.S. leaders often adhere to consistent patterns. Similarly, Koliev and Lundgren (2021) suggest that diplomatic visits to the U.S. by foreign leaders are shaped by habitual behaviors. Thus, we hypothesize that Russian diplomatic visits follow similar patterns, with leaders frequently visiting the same countries over successive years, potentially displaying observable coordination between the president, prime minister, and foreign minister.

4.2 Methodology

Our research aims to explore the determinants of leader visits, with a particular emphasis on how these factors vary depending on the role of the leader. We use high-level leader visits (presidential visits, prime minister visits and foreign minister visits) as our dependent variables. To facilitate this, we define our dependent variables using binary indicators: (i) “Presidential Visit_{ct}” takes the value 1 if country *c* receives an official visit from the president of Russia in year *t*. (ii) “prime minister visit_{ct}” takes the value 1 if country *c* receives an official visit from the Russian prime minister in year *t*. (iii) Finally, “foreign minister visit_{ct}” is coded as 1 if country *c* receives an official visit from the Russian foreign minister in year *t*. Taking instances of multiple visits to the same country in a single year as a single visit,¹⁹ our final panel dataset on official visits yields to 295 presidential, 164 prime minister and 672 foreign minister visits between 1991 and 2023.²⁰

Since our dependent variables are binary, we conduct separate probit regressions for the president, prime minister, and foreign minister. This approach allows us to identify both common patterns and distinctions in their visit behaviors. If a country received multiple visits in a given year, the dependent variable is still coded as 1, indicating that at least one visit occurred. This approach is consistent with the binary nature of our dependent variable, which captures the occurrence of a visit rather than its frequency.

We observe that certain countries receive multiple high-level presidential visits within the same year. Between 1991 and 2023, out of 295 official presidential visits, the maximum number of visits was four, observed for Ukraine (2001, 2004) and Kazakhstan (2008). Additionally, three visits in the same year were recorded for countries such as Belarus (2014, 2000), Germany (2007, 2009), Kyrgyzstan (2019), Turkey (2018), Kazakhstan (2002), France (2003), and Italy (2009), while the remaining cases involved two visits per year. Given the limited instances of multiple visits and the fact that the data are not sufficiently dispersed (with a smaller variance than the mean), employing a logit or probit regression model is more appropriate than a Poisson regression model. However, for robustness and to capture variation in the intensity of visits, we also present the results of the Poisson regression model, as done in prior studies (see Poisson regression model in Kastner & Saunders, 2012; negative binomial in Balci, 2024b) in the Appendix. This dual approach allows us to examine whether the factors influencing the decision to visit differ from those affecting the intensity of visits.

We built the following probit specification over our country panel for the period 1991–2021,²¹ for 171 countries as follows:

¹⁹ We would like to note that there are instances where certain countries receive multiple presidential visits or visits from the Russian prime minister within a single year.

²⁰ These numbers represent the final dataset in panel format, with some observations lost due to the absence of certain countries when merging with the determinants of visits.

²¹ Since the resources variable is available only up to 2021, we limit our dataset to the period from 1991 to 2021 to ensure comprehensive coverage of both countries and control variables. However, when including all control variables -particularly the alliance measure, which is available only until 2018-our analysis

$$\Pr(\text{Leader Visits}) = f(\text{Strategic Interests}, \text{Domestic Influences}, \text{Multilateral Interests}, \text{International Practice}) \quad (1)$$

$$\Pr(\text{Leader Visit}_{ct}) = f(\alpha + \beta_1 \text{Economic Variables}_{ct-1} + \beta_2 \text{Political Variables}_{ct-1} + \beta_3 \text{Military Variables}_{ct-1} + \beta_3 \text{Domestic Variables}_{ct-1} + \beta_3 \text{IO Variables}_{ct-1} + \beta_4 \text{Visit}_{ct-1} + \mu_t + u_{ct}) \quad (2)$$

where in Eqs. (1) and (2) f is the probit link function and Leader Visit_{ct} is a binary indicator defined as above and demonstrating a leader's visit (president, prime minister or foreign minister) to country c in year t . In the above specification, μ_t represents year fixed effects and u_{ct} the error term. All standard errors are clustered by country.

The economic variables include the target country's population (in logarithms), GDP per capita (in logarithms), GDP growth, resources measured as the natural resource rents as a percentage of GDP, the geographical distance between Moscow and recipient capitals (in logarithms), the share of exports of recipient countries in Russian exports (in cube root), the share of imports of recipient countries in Russian imports (in cube root), the share of total trade of recipient countries in Russian total trade (in cube root).²² All economic variables, except distance and trade variables, are sourced from the World Development Indicators (WDI, World Bank n.d.). The distance data is taken from Le Centre d'Études Prospectives et d'Informations Internationales (Mayer & Zignago, 2011). The trade variables are obtained from The World Integrated Trade Solution (WITS, 2024) software provided by the World Bank. The political variables include a dummy variable for major power status (taking the value of 1 for countries with permanent membership in the UNSC, as well as Japan and Germany, and 0 otherwise), the similarity of voting in the UNGA with the U.S., measured by the distance from the U.S. in ideal points in a given year (Voeten et al., 2009), Signorino and Ritter's (1999) S scores and Häge's (2011) scores, Scott's π and Cohen's κ . The military variables include the military spending ratio (in cube root), defense alliance and CSTO Membership dummies. The domestic influences variables include the electoral democracy index from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project (Pemstein et al., 2018; Coppedge et al., 2024) and the weighted conflict measure/index from the Cross-National Time-Series Data (CNTS) Database (Banks & Wilson, 2024).²³ All of the economic, political, military variables except distance and CSTO Membership are lagged by one year to avoid potential endogeneity concerns. IO variables consists of the SCO, ASEAN, and EEU memberships.

The model specification includes lagged values of all of the visit variables. Specifically, the model controls not only for the lagged value of the dependent variable, but also for the types of other visits made in the previous year. Visit_{ct-1} is a binary variable, coded 1 if country c receives a leader visit in year $t-1$ and 0 otherwise. To comprehensively understand the dynamic and interconnected nature of diplomatic relations, this analysis considers the impact of past high-level visits by the president,

becomes restricted to the period from 1991 to 2018 due to the non-availability of the alliance data beyond that year.

²² As in Lebovic and Saunders (2016) the cube root transformation is applied to reduce outliers.

²³ Cross-National Time-Series Data, <https://www.cntsdata.com/>.

prime minister, and foreign minister on future visit patterns. Since successive visits by different leaders show an ongoing importance in bilateral ties, these lagged values help explain the persistence in diplomatic efforts. Regarding the lagged dependent variables in the model specifications, we expect a positive impact of previous visits on the likelihood of subsequent visits by the same leader from the descriptive evidence in Table 2.²⁴ Besides, by including lagged values of visit variables as explanatory variables, we can also analyze the influence of previous visits from different leaders on each other's visits.

The correlation matrix and its corresponding heatmap are presented in Table A6 and Figure A3, respectively, in the Appendix. The variance inflation factors (VIFs), detailed in Table A7 in Appendix, are all below five, indicating that concerns regarding multicollinearity among the variables are effectively mitigated. Table A8 in Appendix presents descriptive statistics of the explanatory variables.

4.3 Estimation results

4.3.1 Results

Firstly, we focus on the determinants of presidential visits and present the results of our probit specifications in Tables 6 and 7. In Table 6, we provide a baseline specification, excluding the lagged dependent variable and other visit variables to check the robustness of the results.²⁵ In Table 7, we report the results of a dynamic specification where we control for previous visits by the president, prime minister, and foreign minister. A comparison of Tables 6 and 7 shows that the results are largely consistent between the static and dynamic specifications. From this point forward, we will focus on interpreting the dynamic specification (Table 7). The results align with our expectations. The coefficient plots for the model, which includes all controls (column 7, of Table 7), are presented in Fig. 8 and display only the variables that are robustly significant.

Our analysis of economic factors reveals a correlation between a country's population size, GDP per capita, GDP growth and the likelihood of receiving presidential visits. This finding suggests that Russian leaders prioritize engagement with large and prosperous states. Figure A4 and Table 8 in the Appendix display the margin-plots and average marginal effects for the model incorporating all control variables (last two columns of Table 7). These visualizations are based on the model with all variables set to their respective sample means. The coefficient estimates suggest that, for instance 1% rise in population corresponds to a 25% points rise in the likelihood

²⁴ From the descriptive evidence in Table 2, we expect that leader visits are more likely to follow a visit in the previous year, indicating that the coefficient of the lagged dependent variable should be positive in these specifications. However, in Table 2, we do not control for other factors. Without econometric modeling, we cannot definitively conclude that persistence exists.

²⁵ To address multicollinearity concerns, since EEU and CSTO memberships largely overlap in terms of member countries, we include each membership variable separately in our regressions. Similarly, the Defense variable from the ATOP database and the alliance measure (Scott's π score of similarity, Håge, 2011) are also included separately. As the π score offers greater variation and incorporates information on defense pacts, we opt to prioritize that measure in our analysis.

Table 6 Determinants of the visits by President (1991–2021)

	DV: President						
	ECON	POL	MIL	DOM	IO	ALL (EEU)	ALL (CSTO)
Population	0.236*** (0.000)	0.222*** (0.000)	0.325*** (0.000)	0.242*** (0.000)	0.212*** (0.000)	0.257*** (0.000)	0.271*** (0.000)
GDP per Capita	0.075* (0.064)	0.182*** (0.000)	0.229*** (0.000)	0.162*** (0.002)	0.119*** (0.001)	0.213*** (0.000)	0.222*** (0.000)
Exports	0.206*** (0.001)	0.136*** (0.000)	0.105*** (0.003)	0.174*** (0.004)	0.152*** (0.000)	0.109*** (0.002)	0.094** (0.014)
Imports	0.262*** (0.000)	0.301*** (0.000)	0.298*** (0.000)	0.269*** (0.000)	0.257*** (0.001)	0.303*** (0.000)	0.318*** (0.000)
GDP Growth	0.158*** (0.001)	0.102* (0.070)	0.151*** (0.003)	0.147*** (0.002)	0.138*** (0.004)	0.118** (0.025)	0.115** (0.028)
Resources	0.006 (0.262)	0.004 (0.322)	−0.001 (0.831)	−0.003 (0.551)	0.005 (0.259)	−0.000 (0.984)	0.001 (0.826)
Distance	−0.650*** (0.000)	−0.358*** (0.000)	−0.479*** (0.000)	−0.670*** (0.000)	−0.617*** (0.000)	−0.265** (0.014)	−0.280** (0.013)
Major Power		0.362* (0.060)				0.266 (0.211)	0.253 (0.219)
UNGA Voting		0.450*** (0.000)				0.294 (0.119)	0.269 (0.165)
Alliance		1.413*** (0.000)				1.295*** (0.000)	1.147*** (0.003)
Military Exp.			−0.088*** (0.000)			−0.050* (0.094)	−0.060* (0.059)
Defense Alliance			1.311*** (0.000)				
Democracy				−0.841*** (0.003)		−0.473 (0.333)	−0.401 (0.412)
Conflict				−0.000 (0.346)		−0.000 (0.369)	−0.000 (0.300)
SCO					0.674*** (0.001)	0.038 (0.883)	0.014 (0.954)
EEU					0.746*** (0.009)	0.782*** (0.004)	
ASEAN					−0.287 (0.186)	−0.838*** (0.000)	−0.800*** (0.001)
CSTO							0.459** (0.046)
Observations	4,118	3,658	3,780	4,108	4,118	3,359	3,359
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES

The results of the probit specifications. Robust standards are clustered by country. p values in parentheses *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. All of the economic, political and visit variables except distance are lagged by one year. In columns 3, 7 and 8, our analysis is restricted to the period from 1991–2018 due to the non-availability of alliance data beyond that year

Table 7 Dynamic specifications: determinants of President visits (1991–2021)

	DV: President						
	ECON	POL	MIL	DOM	IO	ALL (EEU)	ALL (CSTO)
Population	0.212*** (0.000)	0.215*** (0.000)	0.313*** (0.000)	0.220*** (0.000)	0.194*** (0.000)	0.253*** (0.000)	0.266*** (0.000)
GDP per Capita	0.067* (0.085)	0.174*** (0.000)	0.222*** (0.000)	0.145*** (0.005)	0.109*** (0.001)	0.207*** (0.000)	0.217*** (0.000)
Exports	0.184*** (0.002)	0.131*** (0.001)	0.099*** (0.006)	0.160*** (0.005)	0.139*** (0.001)	0.105*** (0.004)	0.089** (0.017)
Imports	0.232*** (0.000)	0.294*** (0.000)	0.297*** (0.000)	0.245*** (0.001)	0.238*** (0.001)	0.308*** (0.000)	0.323*** (0.000)
GDP Growth	0.154*** (0.001)	0.104* (0.075)	0.152*** (0.005)	0.145*** (0.003)	0.137*** (0.005)	0.120** (0.026)	0.117** (0.032)
Resources	0.006 (0.234)	0.005 (0.257)	−0.000 (0.901)	−0.002 (0.669)	0.006 (0.224)	0.001 (0.913)	0.002 (0.728)
Distance	−0.607*** (0.000)	−0.343*** (0.000)	−0.466*** (0.000)	−0.630*** (0.000)	−0.587*** (0.000)	−0.256** (0.017)	−0.271** (0.015)
Major Power		0.311 (0.107)				0.237 (0.265)	0.223 (0.276)
UNGA Voting		0.430*** (0.000)				0.279 (0.132)	0.254 (0.177)
Alliance		1.388*** (0.000)				1.286*** (0.000)	1.138*** (0.003)
Military Exp.			−0.092*** (0.000)			−0.056* (0.061)	−0.066** (0.037)
Defense Alliance			1.294*** (0.000)				
Democracy				−0.742*** (0.006)		−0.469 (0.334)	−0.394 (0.417)
Conflict				−0.000 (0.450)		−0.000 (0.417)	−0.000 (0.336)
SCO					0.641*** (0.002)	0.050 (0.845)	0.026 (0.917)
EEU					0.690*** (0.006)	0.782*** (0.001)	
ASEAN					−0.290 (0.166)	−0.842*** (0.000)	−0.803*** (0.001)
CSTO							0.460** (0.042)
President Visits	0.085 (0.598)	−0.105 (0.500)	−0.169 (0.300)	0.040 (0.799)	−0.007 (0.966)	−0.194 (0.208)	−0.189 (0.225)
Prime Minister	0.348*** (0.007)	0.233* (0.091)	0.270* (0.056)	0.314** (0.013)	0.341*** (0.008)	0.238 (0.110)	0.227 (0.131)

Table 7 (continued)

	DV: President						
	ECON	POL	MIL	DOM	IO	ALL (EEU)	ALL (CSTO)
Foreign Minister	0.309*** (0.001)	0.217** (0.037)	0.245** (0.012)	0.274*** (0.005)	0.276*** (0.004)	0.203* (0.059)	0.209* (0.053)
Observations	4,118	3,658	3,780	4,108	4,118	3,359	3,359
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES

The results of the probit specifications. Robust standards are clustered by country. p values in parentheses *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. All of the economic, political and visit variables except distance are lagged by one year. In columns 3, 7 and 8, our analysis is restricted to the period from 1991–2018 due to the non-availability of alliance data beyond that year

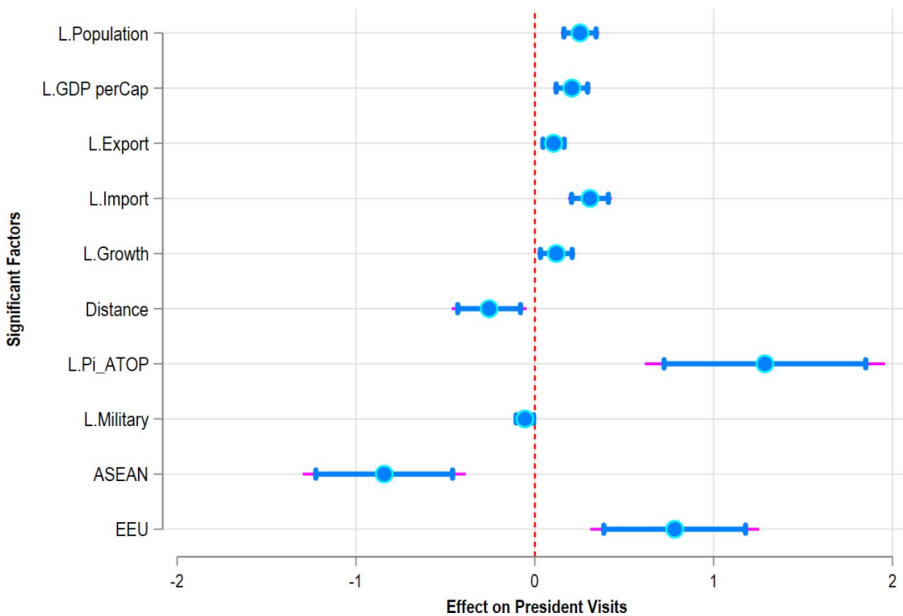


Fig. 8 Coefficient plots for significant variables for Presidential Visits. Note: These coefficients are the significant ones from the results of the dynamic specification with all controls (Table 7, Column 7)

of presidential visits, whereas 1% increase in GDP per capita results in 21% points increase in the same likelihood.

The distance between Moscow and the recipient capital negatively and significantly impacts the likelihood of presidential visits. According to the marginal effects, when we take all variables at their means, 1% increase in the simple distance between capitals in kilometers decreases the probability of presidential visits by 26% points (Table A9 in the Appendix). This indicates that the further a country is away from Moscow, the less likely it is to receive a presidential visit, possibly highlighting the importance of neighboring countries and regions. In addition, Russia has several

bilateral engagements with geographically closer countries, making them more frequent destinations for presidential visits.

The coefficient on resources is not significant, aligning with our expectations. As a resource-rich country, we anticipated that Russian leaders' visits might not prioritize resource-rich countries due to several strategic geopolitical and economic reasons. Geopolitical strategy often takes superiority, with visits focused on countries of strategic importance—driven by potential alliances, the exertion of soft power, and security concerns—rather than those rich in resources. Economically, Russia, being resource-rich itself, may seek to diversify its economic partnerships, favor countries that offer other investment opportunities, industrial, or financial benefits. Additionally, Russia already have established resource agreements that do not necessitate frequent visits (Chadwick and Long, 2023).

The results across all models in the table provide strong evidence in support of the strategic interests Hypothesis regarding economic factors. The coefficients for both export and import variables are consistently positive and statistically significant across all estimations.²⁶ According to the coefficient estimates in Table A9, for example, a 1% increase in exports raises the likelihood of presidential visits by 11% points, while a 1% increase in imports raises the likelihood by 31% points. This confirms our expectations that Russian high-level visits are driven by both export and import activities. Specifically, the positive relationship between exports and high-level visits suggests that Russian leaders prioritize countries that play a critical role in expanding market access for Russian goods, likely to boost domestic production and economic activity. Similarly, the significant positive effect of imports underscores the importance of trade dependencies, particularly Russia's reliance on importing consumer goods, technological products, and industrial inputs to sustain domestic growth. This finding aligns with our argument that, despite Russia's trade surplus, imports are crucial for maintaining supply chain continuity and supporting key sectors of the economy.

Regarding the political variables, while democracy and voting similarity with the U.S. are not found to be robustly significant, the alliance measure (Scott's π score of similarity, Häge, 2011) is positively significant across all models. This suggests that as a country's alliance with Russia strengthens, it is more likely to receive visits from the Russian president. Specifically, 0.1 unit increase in the alliance similarity index decreases the probability of visits by 1.28% (Table A9 in Appendix). This may stem from the fact that stronger alliances indicate deeper political and security ties, prompting high-level visits to reinforce these relationships. Such visits may serve as a means of solidifying defense cooperation, reaffirming mutual interests, and demonstrating political alignment on key international issues.

As for the military variables, our findings strongly support the hypothesis that Russian security interests play a critical role in determining high-level visits. The share of military expenditure is consistently and negatively significant, confirming that Russia tends to visit countries with lower military spending. This aligns with our expectation that Russia avoids heavily militarized, Western-aligned states, which may have stronger ties to NATO or the U.S., and instead focuses on less milita-

²⁶ As seen in Table A10 in Appendix, the results are robust to inclusion of trade separately.

rized nations where it may perceive greater opportunities for defense collaboration or geopolitical influence. On the other hand, the defense alliance variable is positively significant across all models, suggesting that Russia is more likely to visit countries with which it shares formal defense agreements. This indicates that defense alliances are a major driver of high-level diplomatic engagements, reinforcing the notion that shared security concerns and formal military cooperation lead to more frequent visits. Additionally, CSTO membership is also positively significant, indicating that member states of the CSTO receive more visits compared to non-members. This further highlights Russia's strategic focus on maintaining and strengthening relationships within the CSTO framework, as these countries are integral to its regional security and military interests.

Despite expectations drawn from the literature, the results indicate that democracy does not have a significant influence on the likelihood of Russian high-level visits. The findings suggest that the regime type of the destination country is not a key factor in Russian foreign policy, likely reflecting Russia's pragmatic approach to diplomacy, which prioritizes strategic and geopolitical interests over the promotion of shared values or governance models. This result supports the idea that, as an authoritarian regime, Russia is not deterred by the political structures of its potential destination countries, whether democratic or autocratic. Similarly, we find no significant effect of conflicts on the likelihood of Russian high-level visits. Although conflicts could have been expected to shape foreign policy priorities by encouraging visits to support peace efforts or intervene in strategic regions, the lack of a significant relationship suggests that Russia's high-level visits are not systematically driven by the presence of conflicts. This may indicate that Russia either pursues its conflict-related interests through other means or only engages diplomatically in very specific contexts where conflicts align closely with its national or regional goals. Therefore, the lack of significant effects for both democracy and conflicts suggests that Russian high-level visits are shaped less by the domestic characteristics of destination countries and more by broader strategic, economic, and geopolitical considerations.

As for the IO variables, surprisingly we find no effect of SCO membership while we observe positive and significant effects of EEU membership on presidential visits. Holding all other factors constant at their mean values, the probability of a Russian president visiting an EEU member stands at 9.4%, whereas it is only 1.8% for non-members. The EEU's direct relevance to Russia's economic, political and regional integration objectives makes it a significant driver of high-level diplomatic visits. In contrast, the SCO, with its focus on security cooperation and shared leadership, may not necessitate as many high-level diplomatic engagements from Russia.

The negative significance of Russian presidential visits to ASEAN nations can be attributed to several factors. ASEAN's inherent structural barriers to foreign influence, combined with member states' reservations about the U.S. sanctions and the Ukraine crisis since 2014, have created a challenging environment for Russia. Consequently, Russia has shifted its focus towards China in its Asian strategy, becoming increasingly Sinocentric.²⁷ This shift in focus may have resulted in a decreased

²⁷ See, https://www.osw.waw.pl/en/publikacje/osw-commentary/2012-10-09/russias-turn-towards-asia-more-words-actions#_ftn8.

emphasis on other regional relationships, including ASEAN, leading to fewer presidential visits. As Russia prioritizes its ties with China, it may allocate fewer resources and attention to Southeast Asia.

Turning to the visit variables, we find no significant effect of previous presidential visits on subsequent presidential visits. However, previous foreign minister visits show a positive and significant impact on presidential visits. On the other hand, the significance of prime minister visits disappears after controlling for other variables. The positive and significant effect of previous foreign minister visits, even after accounting for multiple factors, suggests that these visits likely play a key role in laying the groundwork for future presidential engagements.

Moving to the determinants of prime minister and foreign minister visits, we present the results of our probit specifications in Tables 8 and 9. Population, GDP per capita, and exports are positively significant across all leadership levels. In Fig. 9, we display these significant economic factors influencing all leaders, suggesting that market size and export activities are key drivers of diplomatic engagements. As with presidential visits, distance has a negative effect on foreign minister visits, while for prime minister visits, distance is negative in most models except one specification.

In contrast, GDP growth and imports influence only presidential visits, indicating that presidents prioritize countries experiencing economic expansion and those from which Russia imports heavily. This reflects the broader diplomatic role of the presidency, which focuses on securing long-term trade agreements and fostering economic cooperation. Prime ministers and foreign ministers, by contrast, tend to focus on more specialized or technical aspects of bilateral relations, where these broader economic factors play a lesser role (Wehner & Thies, 2021).

Turning to the political and military variables, voting similarity with the U.S., major power status, and military expenditures are insignificant for both prime ministers and foreign ministers. However, the defense alliance measure is significant across all leaders, and the π score of similarity (which covers all alliances) is significant for both prime minister and presidential visits. This suggests that alliances play a critical role in shaping presidential diplomacy, particularly in consolidating key political and security relationships. While prime ministers also focus on economic or technical cooperation, alliances appear to be more central to their visits compared to foreign ministers. This pattern indicates that alliances are viewed as part of broader geopolitical alignments, managed primarily at the highest levels of diplomacy, whereas foreign ministers typically address more specific diplomatic or regional issues.

Regarding domestic influences, the democracy index has a negative and significant effect on foreign minister visits but remains insignificant for presidential and prime minister visits. This may suggest that in the case of presidential visits, the focus is on broader state-driven strategic priorities, such as security, economic partnerships, or geopolitical influence, rather than regime type or ideological alignment. As the head of state, the president's diplomacy reflects Russia's national interests, often prioritizing high-level engagements that transcend ideological differences. In contrast, foreign ministers, who are more involved in issue-specific diplomacy, may avoid visiting democratic countries, reflecting the state's ideological stance and potential conflicts with democratic governance.

Table 8 Determinants of Foreign Minister visits (1991–2021)

DV: Foreign Minister

	ECON	POL	MIL	DOM	IO	ALL (EEU)
Population	0.201*** (0.000)	0.191*** (0.000)	0.210*** (0.000)	0.216*** (0.000)	0.202*** (0.000)	0.194*** (0.000)
GDP per Capita	0.163*** (0.000)	0.214*** (0.000)	0.194*** (0.000)	0.254*** (0.000)	0.187*** (0.000)	0.256*** (0.000)
Exports	0.124*** (0.003)	0.112** (0.026)	0.094* (0.098)	0.097** (0.040)	0.098* (0.091)	0.105* (0.052)
Imports	0.014 (0.753)	0.023 (0.710)	0.001 (0.978)	0.032 (0.467)	−0.008 (0.880)	−0.017 (0.778)
GDP Growth	0.102*** (0.003)	0.068 (0.133)	0.087** (0.027)	0.086** (0.018)	0.092*** (0.004)	0.057 (0.230)
Resources	−0.001 (0.670)	−0.004 (0.256)	−0.005** (0.047)	−0.011*** (0.005)	−0.001 (0.693)	−0.013*** (0.003)
Distance	−0.421*** (0.000)	−0.333*** (0.000)	−0.366*** (0.000)	−0.441*** (0.000)	−0.412*** (0.000)	−0.315*** (0.001)
Major Power		0.461** (0.041)				0.278 (0.230)
UNGA Voting		0.277** (0.028)				0.174 (0.322)
Alliance		0.599** (0.045)				0.454 (0.233)
Military Exp.			0.019 (0.147)			0.040 (0.160)
Defense Alliance			0.671*** (0.000)			
Democracy				−0.896*** (0.000)		−0.647** (0.042)
Conflict				−0.000 (0.332)		−0.000 (0.763)
SCO					0.356** (0.025)	0.071 (0.781)
EEU					1.020*** (0.008)	0.941*** (0.006)
ASEAN					0.082 (0.574)	−0.250 (0.230)
President Visits	0.339*** (0.000)	0.209** (0.040)	0.272*** (0.003)	0.290*** (0.001)	0.276*** (0.006)	0.195** (0.045)
Prime Minister	−0.127 (0.384)	−0.337*** (0.005)	−0.218 (0.110)	−0.173 (0.192)	−0.125 (0.393)	−0.310*** (0.008)
Foreign Minister	0.116 (0.284)	0.037 (0.774)	0.075 (0.481)	0.075 (0.489)	0.079 (0.449)	0.011 (0.925)
Observations	4,118	3,658	3,780	4,108	4,118	3,359
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES

The results of the probit specifications. Robust standards are clustered by country. p values in parentheses *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. All of the economic, political and visit variables except distance are lagged by one year. In columns 3,7 and 8, our analysis is restricted to the period from 1991–2018 due to the non-availability of alliance data beyond that year

Table 9 Determinants of Prime Minister visits (1991–2021)

	DV: Prime Minister					
	ECON	POL	MIL	DOM	IO	ALL (EEU)
Population	0.176*** (0.000)	0.177*** (0.000)	0.219*** (0.000)	0.198*** (0.000)	0.148*** (0.000)	0.196*** (0.001)
GDP per Capita	0.057 (0.106)	0.110** (0.042)	0.108*** (0.008)	0.118** (0.019)	0.077** (0.029)	0.116* (0.062)
Exports	0.127*** (0.008)	0.093** (0.048)	0.090* (0.053)	0.112** (0.021)	0.103*** (0.009)	0.095* (0.064)
Imports	0.100* (0.084)	0.101 (0.272)	0.136** (0.038)	0.101* (0.095)	0.125* (0.054)	0.125 (0.127)
GDP Growth	0.068 (0.373)	−0.008 (0.943)	0.036 (0.739)	0.025 (0.804)	0.032 (0.735)	−0.042 (0.747)
Resources	−0.006 (0.146)	−0.009 (0.113)	−0.011** (0.037)	−0.013** (0.040)	−0.006 (0.162)	−0.012 (0.109)
Distance	−0.362*** (0.000)	−0.140 (0.178)	−0.283*** (0.000)	−0.390*** (0.000)	−0.376*** (0.000)	−0.135 (0.257)
Major Power		0.246 (0.390)				0.194 (0.560)
UNGA Voting		0.292** (0.010)				0.231 (0.166)
Alliance		1.033*** (0.000)				0.982*** (0.001)
Military Exp.			−0.058*** (0.005)			−0.025 (0.472)
Defense Alliance			0.614*** (0.000)			
Democracy				−0.648** (0.045)		−0.363 (0.439)
Conflict				−0.000 (0.109)		−0.000 (0.222)
SCO					0.426*** (0.002)	−0.051 (0.802)
EEU					0.100 (0.734)	−0.916 (0.166)
ASEAN					0.441* (0.099)	−0.013 (0.959)
President Visits	0.390*** (0.005)	0.298** (0.024)	0.298** (0.033)	0.360** (0.010)	0.369*** (0.010)	0.335** (0.012)
Prime Minister	0.163 (0.382)	0.100 (0.612)	0.134 (0.472)	0.121 (0.547)	0.146 (0.441)	0.068 (0.736)
Foreign Minister	0.225** (0.038)	0.120 (0.273)	0.209* (0.052)	0.179 (0.101)	0.212* (0.056)	0.126 (0.255)
Observations	3,785	3,496	3,480	3,775	3,785	3,210
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES

The results of the probit specifications. Robust standards are clustered by country. p values in parentheses *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. All of the economic, political and visit variables except distance are lagged by one year. In columns 3,7 and 8, our analysis is restricted to the period from 1991–2018 due to the non-availability of alliance data beyond that year

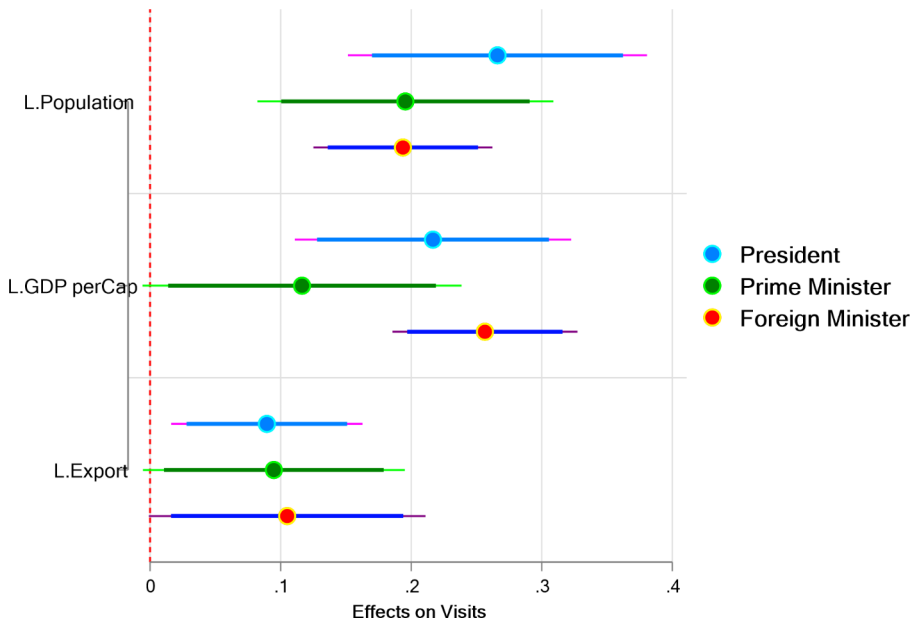


Fig. 9 Coefficient plots for significant factors for all leaders. Note: These coefficients are the significant ones for all of the leaders, from the results of the dynamic specification with all controls (Tables 7, 8 and 9, Column 7)

For the international organization (IO) variables, EEU membership significantly influences foreign minister and presidential visits. This highlights the importance of regional integration within the EEU, especially for presidential diplomacy. Interestingly, SCO or ASEAN membership does not significantly affect visits for any of the leaders, indicating that ties to these organizations are not primary drivers of Russian high-level visits, aligning with broader trends in Russia's Asia policy.

None of the lagged dependent variables are significant in the model specifications, indicating no persistence in visits by the same leader over time. However, when lagged values of visits by different leaders are added as explanatory variables, we observe a notable influence of prior visits on subsequent engagements. Table 9 shows that prime minister visits are positively affected by previous presidential visits, while Table 8 indicates that foreign minister visits are positively influenced by previous presidential visits and are either negatively influenced or unaffected by previous prime minister visits. Additionally, Table 7 shows that presidential visits are influenced by both prime minister and foreign minister visits, with the effect of foreign minister visits being particularly pronounced. Taken together, these results suggest that visits by the prime minister and foreign minister may serve as preliminary engagements, helping to address initial diplomatic or technical issues, foster relations, and lay the groundwork for more significant high-level discussions that typically require a presidential visit. This evidence highlights a sequential and collaborative approach in Russian foreign diplomacy, where lower-level visits help prepare the stage for presidential engagement, reflecting a structured and strategic use of diplomatic visits.

4.3.2 Robustness

To ensure that our results are robust and not dependent on the way variables are operationalized or specific estimation methods we conduct several additional tests. First, we replace exports and imports with trade shares. The findings remain robust with the inclusion of trade shares (Table A10). Notably, the trade share of the target country in Russian total trade is significant for both presidential and prime minister visits but not for foreign minister visits. This result aligns with the previous findings, where import shares were also insignificant for foreign minister visits across all models.

Next, we apply alternative similarity scores, replacing Häge's chance-corrected Scott's π scores with chance-corrected kappa scores, unweighted S-scores, and weighted S-scores measures (Table A11). The unweighted S-scores offer a broad view of alliance patterns by treating all alliances equally, capturing overall similarity in foreign policy alignment. In contrast, the weighted S-scores provide a more detailed and precise measure by emphasizing the depth and intensity of alliances. Weighted scores give greater importance to more significant or binding alliances, such as defense pacts, thus reflecting the strength of relationships, while unweighted scores focus on the presence or absence of alliances without considering their intensity. The key results for visits remain robust and similar across these alternative indices, confirming the consistency of our findings. Additionally, all of the similarity scores are found to be significant, further supporting the relevance of alliance-based measures in understanding visit patterns.

Next, running multivariate probit estimations, which simultaneously estimates a three-equation probit model using the method of maximum simulated likelihood. Although multivariate probit methodology is not our first choice due to the low correlations among the visit variables (Table A6 in Appendix), we present the results of the multivariate model, inclusive of all controls, in Table A12 in the Appendix. The coefficients derived from the multivariate probit estimations exhibit magnitudes quite similar to those of the probit model and maintain identical significance levels.

To address concerns regarding "clustering" in leader visits (where multiple visits to nearby countries occur in the same trip), we introduced an additional dimension in our analysis focusing on distance. Specifically, for group visits, we added a variable representing the distance between countries visited consecutively within a trip. When there were no group visits, we retained the standard distance measure. This approach was aimed at capturing any potential clustering effect where a leader might visit multiple countries within a region due to geographic proximity. Despite this additional control for distance, our findings regarding the main determinants of Russian diplomatic visits remained consistent. The coefficients of the key variables did not change significantly, suggesting that the strategic or diplomatic motivations for visits are robust, regardless of any clustering that occurs due to geographic convenience. The results of the regarding regressions for determining the number of presidential visits are shown in the Appendix Table A13.

Another robustness check involves estimating a Poisson model with the count of visits as the dependent variable. Appendix Table A13 presents the results for president and foreign minister visits. For the prime minister's visits, there are only 8 cases of multiple visits within the same year. As such, the dataset does not show sufficient

variation to justify the use of a negative binomial or count-based model, making a logit or probit model more appropriate.

The results of presidential visits' estimations, indicate that most of the main findings -regarding factors like population, distance, GDP per capita, exports, imports, alliances, and ASEAN membership- remain consistent across this alternative approach. This suggests that these variables not only explain the decision to visit but also the extent of the visits. However, for presidential visits, the variables for a foreign minister's visit in the previous year, military share, GDP per capita growth, and EEU membership are found to be insignificant in the Poisson model, suggesting that these factors mainly influence the initial decision to make a visit rather than the frequency of subsequent visits. Specifically, a previous foreign minister visit likely facilitates the groundwork for an initial presidential visit by fostering diplomatic relationships, but it may not determine the extent of subsequent engagements. Similarly, a high military share might prompt an initial visit to initiate defense collaboration, yet ongoing visits may be influenced by other aspects of the relationship, such as economic ties or political changes. GDP per capita growth, while signaling economic development and potential investment opportunities, might not directly influence the frequency of high-level visits if other factors, such as strategic priorities or bilateral tensions, come into play. Additionally, EEU membership prompts initial engagement due to regional integration, but the continuation of visits may be shaped by evolving priorities and emerging global factors.

Furthermore, unlike the decision to visit estimations, the Poisson model shows that UNGA voting similarity with the USA is significant, suggesting that the frequency of visits is influenced by political alignment with Western powers. Higher voting similarity with the USA may encourage repeated diplomatic engagement by Russia, potentially to maintain influence or develop a balancing presence in these countries. Thus, Russia is more likely to invest diplomatically in maintaining ties with countries that are open to both Russian and Western influence, ensuring its strategic interests are protected in a competitive geopolitical environment. For the foreign minister's visits, the main findings remain consistent with the probit estimations, suggesting that same key variables consistently drive the likelihood of visits, regardless of the estimation approach.

5 Conclusion

This study introduces a new dataset of Russian leader visits to foreign countries between 1991 and 2023, contributing significantly to the field of Russian foreign policy studies. The "Russia Visits Dataset" provides a comprehensive and detailed account of official, multilateral, goodwill, public, and private visits by Russian presidents, prime ministers, and foreign ministers. It offers a valuable resource for analyzing Russian diplomatic engagements, particularly in understanding the motivations and determinants of leader visits. The analysis of the dataset reveals significant patterns in the temporal and geographical distribution of Russian leader visits. The historical analysis highlights the cyclical nature of Russian diplomacy, demonstrating periods of increased and decreased activity. The geographical analysis identifies a

strong focus on neighboring countries, particularly Kazakhstan, reflecting the importance of regional stability and economic integration within the EEU. The analysis also highlights the importance of strategic partnerships with major powers like China and Germany, emphasizing the multifaceted nature of Russian foreign policy.

Beyond descriptive analysis, the study employs probit regressions to explore the determinants of Russian leader visits. The analysis finds that economic factors, such as population, GDP per capita, and distance from Moscow, are significant predictors of leader visits. Interestingly, the study shows that the level of democracy and the U.S. alignment are not among the significant determinants of Russian leaders with the exception of foreign minister reflecting a pragmatic tendency in Russian foreign policy choices. The findings also highlight the importance of international organizations, particularly the EEU as a significant determinant in shaping Russian state visits. Visits to SCO countries are insignificant and to ASEAN are negatively significant indicating a different picture than portrayal of Russia's developing of relations with Asia-Pacific countries.

Russia's alliances, including CSTO with security orientation, and defense agreements positively impact on leader visits showcasing Russian foreign policy behavior of seeking political and security alliances. This is also valid for negatively significant impact of high military expenditure on visit preferences. Russian exports and imports play significant roles for foreign visits while resources are insignificant for receiving Russian visits. Previous visits from various leaders tend to influence each other, indicating a sequential and collaborative approach in Russian foreign diplomacy. Our findings suggest that Russia's foreign policy is strategically coordinated among its top leaders, ensuring a consistent and unified diplomatic effort across diverse regions and organizations.

The study's findings contribute to the existing literature on leader visits by providing a new lens for understanding diplomatic practices of a major non-Western power. The scope, orientation, preferences and practices of Russian leader visits present a different case than China and the U.S. Russian state visits depict a major power role aiming to consolidate hegemonic role in Eurasian geography with aspirations for great power role through developing alliances, defense agreements, economic expansion, securing arms supply and paying more attention to rich and populated states with a pragmatic attitude of ignoring regime type. The significant visit determinants in this analysis points out the prioritization of hegemonic role within nearby regions but does not signify a great power diplomacy through foreign visits as witnessed in diplomatic preferences of the U.S. and China.

We also acknowledge limitations of our study that should be addressed in future research. We focused primarily on official visits, necessitating future research to examine the impact of less formal diplomatic encounters. Future research can further explore the motivations behind Russian leader visits by examining the content of the visits. Analyzing the specific agreements signed, issues discussed, and outcomes achieved during these visits can provide deeper insights into Russia's foreign policy goals and strategies. Additionally, exploring the impact of leader visits on public opinion in both Russia and the host country can provide a more nuanced understanding of the broader effects of these diplomatic engagements. Further, comparing the patterns of Russian leader visits with other major powers like China and the U.S.

can reveal important insights into the evolving dynamics of global diplomacy. By addressing these limitations and exploring these avenues for further investigation, future research can build upon this study's findings, enhancing our understanding of Russian foreign policy and its impact on the global stage.

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Declarations

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